accepting his generosity, you chose to judge him by external factors like caste, you have forfeited the chance of immortality,' the Lord informed Utanga.

The Hindu who says that caste discrimination is incompatible with his *dharma* is a better Hindu than one who insists her religion does not permit her to engage a low caste cook in her house (as a senior government official recently did) or claims her faith will not allow her to serve a Dalit boss (which somehow no menial employee in India has yet done). Still, the battles over temple entry to Dalits occurred within living memory; and other instances of the pernicious effect of caste discrimination in the practice of religion are not hard to find. India's first artist to achieve mass popularity, Raja Ravi Varma, did so in the 1890s by printing lithographs of his paintings of Hindu gods, which enabled Dalits to worship in their homes images of the very deities they were not allowed to pray to in the temples, from which they were barred. As I've pointed out a few pages earlier, the great social reformer Sree Narayana Guru in Kerala installed a Shiva-lingam in a temple because Hindus of his Ezhava caste were forbidden from entering the area's established Shiva temples. So the Hindu religion has undoubtedly been complicit in caste discrimination, and the faith's identification with caste oppression has long been the principal negative held against it. Is a religion responsible for the worst behaviour of its followers? Perhaps not; but Hindus collectively need to continue doing all that they can to wash the stain of caste discrimination from the face of their faith.

GURUS AND THE 'GOD MARKET'

Another aspect of popular Hinduism that does not reflect well on it is superstition. Hindus are considered prone to believing in assorted signs and soothsayers; our fondness for astrology, for instance, is widely observed. It is true that a Hindu without a horoscope is like an American without a credit card, and is subject to many of the same disabilities. I even have two horoscopes: one cast for me soon after my birth in London by an expatriate Indian doctor there, another by the family astrologer at the village in Kerala. They didn't match, and to this day, it